



Inspection Report

Mississippi State University
301 Research Boulevard
Starkville, MS 39759

Customer ID: **837**

Certificate: **65-R-0002**

Site: 001

MISSISSIPPI STATE UNIVERSITY

Type: ROUTINE INSPECTION

Date: 31-AUG-2026

2.31(c)(7) Critical

Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC).

As documented in a June 1, 2026 noncompliance letter from the facility to USDA Animal Care, along with a disposition record and the May 22, 2026 IACUC noncompliance meeting minutes, a significant deviation from the approved IACUC study protocol was identified. It was reported that a disabled, non-releasable female adult black vulture was released back into the wild following the conclusion of the study. The principal investigator (PI) released the animal into the wild on March 5, 2026 and subsequently closed the protocol on March 13, 2026. The IACUC noncompliance meeting minutes further note that the PI acknowledged releasing the black vulture associated with Protocol #25-274. Because the approved protocol did not authorize release of the animal, this acknowledgment confirmed that an activity occurred outside the scope of the approved protocol. Within the Protocol #25-274 document, "Recovered Black Vulture for Teaching and Research," multiple sections explain that the bird was originally found with a broken wing, required wing amputation, could not be released, and would be permanently maintained in captivity for teaching purposes. On July 27, 2026 the vulture was recaptured by the facility and now resides at a wildlife rehabilitation center.

This activity constitutes a significant deviation from the approved protocol. Implementing substantial changes to protocols, such as releasing a bird missing part of its wing into the wild, without prior IACUC review and approval deprives the IACUC of its ability to provide appropriate oversight of animal activities and ensure compliance with the Animal Welfare Act. Failure to allow the IACUC to conduct an review of the IACUC protocol may result in serious adverse impacts on animal welfare. Per this section of the regulations, the IACUC must review and approve significant changes to proposals for animal use before the investigators can conduct any additional activities that were not initially described at the time of IACUC approval. Corrected prior to the time of inspection.

2.33(b)(2)

Attending veterinarian and adequate veterinary care.

The facility did not follow the Program of Veterinary Care (PVC) as required. The physical exam record for canine USDA #3800 dated November 25, 2025 documented abnormal findings including gingivitis and moderate dental calculi. The medical record indicates that the last dental prophylaxis was performed on January 14, 2025. Under Section IV-C of the PVC, preventative care requires maintaining clean and healthy teeth, stating that "dental prophylaxis must be performed annually or more frequently if needed." The PVC outlines appropriate methods to prevent, control, diagnose, and treat

Prepared By: BRITTANY KESSLER

USDA, APHIS, Animal Care

Date:

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diseases and injuries. When the PVC is not properly followed, expected medical outcomes may not occur, existing conditions may worsen, or new issues may arise. Correct by September 28, 2026.

This inspection and exit interview were conducted with the attending veterinarian and a facility representative.

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USDA, APHIS, Animal Care

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Species Inspected

Cust No	Cert No	Site	Site Name	Inspection
837	65-R-0002	001	MISSISSIPPI STATE UNIVERSITY	31-AUG-2026

Count	Scientific Name	Common Name
000032	<i>Canis familiaris</i>	DOG ADULT
000005	<i>Capra hircus</i>	DOMESTIC GOAT
000002	<i>Ovis aries aries</i>	SHEEP INCLUDING ALL DOMESTIC BREEDS
000003	<i>Bos taurus</i>	CATTLE / COW / OX
000015	<i>Odocoileus virginianus</i>	WHITE-TAILED DEER
000000	<i>Coragyps atratus</i>	BLACK VULTURE / MEXICAN VULTURE
000019	<i>Equus caballus</i>	DOMESTIC HORSE
000076	Total	